

BADGERS, OTTERS, AND SKUNKS

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THESE THREE GROUPS OF ANIMALS are all members of the weasel family – Mustelidae. Their main characteristics are a long, low-slung body, short legs, and five toes on each foot. They are carnivores, although badgers have a mixed diet. The honey badger is especially fond of honey, as its name suggests. Most mustelids discharge a thick, oily, powerful-smelling fluid called a musk from their anal glands. They use this mostly to send scent messages to other members of the species, usually with their droppings.



Skull

A badger eats meat and plants, and its large canines and broad molar teeth are ideal for this diet. Its jaw muscles are fixed to a rigid bone on the top of the skull, giving the animal a powerful bite.

Badgers

All badgers are thick set with very powerful legs which they use to forage for food and to dig their often extensive burrows. They are nocturnal animals, spending the day underground with others of their social group. There are eight species of true badger, plus the honey badger, which is classed in a sub-family of its own.



Short tail

Long, striped snout



Forepaw print



Hind paw print

Paws

A Eurasian badger's track is unmistakable. Each foot has five toes with a kidney-shaped pad behind. The front claws usually leave marks because they are long.



Long coarse hairs over a dense underfur

Badgers have a good sense of smell.

Eurasian badger

This is the largest badger and has the widest distribution. Females give birth to up to four cubs in February. These are weaned at 12 weeks, when they can forage for themselves.



Otters

These semi-aquatic mustelids occur outside the polar regions in every continent except Australia. Some species are exclusively sea creatures, some use only fresh water, and others use both sea and fresh water. Most have sleeping dens, or holts, on land.



European river otter



Asian short-clawed otter

Paws

Although all otters swim, not all have webbed feet. For example, the European otter has a large amount of webbing. The Asian short-clawed otter has little webbing and uses its paws to find food by touch.



Fur

An otter's coat consists of two layers. A thick under-layer of fine hairs traps air for warmth, and longer, waterproof guard hairs keep the underfur dry.

Badger setts

During the day, badgers live underground in a complex system of tunnels and chambers called a sett. A main badger sett is easily recognized by the entrances with piles of soil outside.



Honey badger

The African honey badger, also known as the ratel, has a thick, loose skin. Predators can find it difficult to pierce its skin, and the badger can twist around inside its skin and bite back.



Movement

With their long back and heavy tail, otters can look clumsy on land. In the water they are graceful swimmers, propelling themselves forward by moving their hindquarters and tail up and down.

Spraints

Otters secrete a powerful scent. They mark their territory by leaving their droppings, called spraints, which smell of this scent, on high points such as rocks.



Skunks

There are 13 species of skunk, which all occur in the Americas. They are best known for their ability to squirt a foul-smelling fluid from their anal glands. They aim this fluid at the eyes of an enemy, and it can cause temporary blindness. Skunks search for insects and other small animals to eat, mainly at night.



Markings

Skunks have bold black and white coat markings. Like the yellow and black stripes of a wasp, these warn would-be predators of danger.

EURASIAN BADGER

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Meles meles*

ORDER Carnivora

FAMILY Mustelidae

DISTRIBUTION Europe and a wide band across Asia

HABITAT Mainly lowland farmland and woodland

DIET Worms, insects, birds, and other small animals, fruit, cereals, fungi

SIZE Length: 1 m (3.3 ft)

LIFESPAN About 7 years

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